GOC begged and pleaded with faceless men at the other end of the telephone to extricate the doomed brigade. On 10 October when a visibly shaken Kaul made a hurried exit to ‘consult Mr Nehru’ both Rikh and Dalvi were certain that it was only a matter of time before they were allowed to pull back and take up more credible fighting positions.

But that order never came.

Rikh had to quickly put all these thoughts behind him and focus on the long night ahead of him. Would the Chinese put in a night assault? It was quite likely. The cards were all held by the Chinese. Now all that Rikh could do was wait and watch. He knew every man in the battalion was where he was supposed to be and all the patrols were out. The officers and JCOs were moving about the defences amidst the men who were on duty, while others were trying to get some sleep. There was no report of any activity. After a while, with nothing more to be done, Rikh retired to his corner of the command bunker to get some much needed sleep.

The last Rajput position was at Bridge 3 where Alpha Company was deployed under the command of Captain Ravi Eipe. This was the original Dhola post. A platoon of Assam Rifles was occupying the top of the spur that overlooked the Rongla Nullah that came down from Tsangdhar. No. 2 Platoon under CHM (company havildar major) Saudagar Singh was holding the ground to the left, approximately 600 feet below the Assam Rifles position. Another twenty feet below, No. 1 Platoon under Subedar Basdeo Singh was just above the river, overlooking the bridge. Company HQ was directly behind and above Basdeo Singh’s position, while to its right was No. 3 Platoon under Jemadar Ghanshyam Singh. The last platoon, from its position on the spur, not only overlooked the Rongla Nullah, it covered the track that led to Brigade HQ that was sited a kilometre further behind.

On the same spur, but deployed further up in depth were 1/9 GR. Though downstream of the Rajput positions was Bridge 1 and 2 where 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers were deployed, the only exit from the Nam Ka Chu Valley for 2 Rajput would be through the Rongla Nullah. All the men knew this exit route as they had entered the valley this way. Given the nature of the terrain, any attack on this position would have to come from the west. As a result, Alpha Company was tactically perhaps the best situated.

9 Punjab was at Bridge 2 while 4 Grenadiers, the last entrant into the valley, was holding the position at Bridge 1. One company was deployed at